FOR THE HIGHLANDS · OCTOBER 5 – NOVEMBER 29, 2026

Endurance for the trip

Eight weeks. The goal is to walk the Chicabal stairs slowly and still have legs the next day. You already use the elliptical four or five times a week. This keeps that, and adds two short strength days for the knees and the hills.

What this is. A home plan for a 47-year-old who already exercises, with well-controlled diabetes, a thyroid condition, and sensitive knees. It is not a medical prescription. If your doctor has set limits, those win.

Knees. Muscle tiredness is fine. Sharp pain, swelling, or a knee that complains the next morning means that move is out. Skip it. Do not push through it.

Diabetes. Check your glucose the way you already do before you start. If you feel low, stop and treat it. Keep juice or glucose tablets in the room. A session can lower your sugar for a few hours afterward.

Thyroid. On a flat day, do the short version at the bottom of this page. Do not make it up by doing double the next day.

Stop the session for chest pain, dizziness, or shortness of breath that is not normal effort.

The week

Four days are the plan. The fifth day is the long elliptical, which is the one that builds hiking endurance. If a week is heavy, skip the long day and add 10 minutes to Tuesday instead.

Monday	Strength A, hike legs. About 35 minutes, then an optional 10 easy minutes on the elliptical.
Tuesday	Elliptical, steady. A pace where you can say a full sentence.
Wednesday	Rest. A slow walk outside is fine. No workout.
Thursday	Strength B, the support work. About 30 minutes.
Friday	Elliptical hills. Short harder bits, then easy.
Saturday	Long elliptical. This is the Chicabal practice. Optional if you are wiped out.
Sunday	Rest.

Move the days if you need to. Keep a rest day between the two strength days. Do not put Strength A and the long elliptical on the same day.

Elliptical shoes are your Ultraboosts. The beige trail shoes stay off that machine. Once a week, wear the trail shoes for a flat 20-minute walk outside, so they are broken in by December. If the pavement bothers the knees, shorten it.

> **Short version, any day you are flat.** 10 easy minutes on the elliptical. One set of sit-to-stands. One set of glute bridges. One set of step-downs, only if the knee is quiet. Then stop. That day counts.

How hard, and for how many sets

Weeks of October 5 and October 12: two sets of each exercise. From October 19 on: three sets. Rest about a minute between sets. The last two reps of a set should be work, not a grind. If you cannot keep the same speed on the way down, the weight is too heavy. Start with the empty bar, or no bar.

Add weight only when three sets feel boring and the knees are calm the next morning. One small plate is enough of a jump.

Strength A — hike legs

Monday. Warm up with 5 easy minutes on the elliptical first.

KNEES AND GETTING OUT OF A CHAIR

Sit-to-stand

Use the flat bench. Feet flat, sit all the way down, stand up without rocking. Arms reach forward. 8 to 10 reps. If you need a hand, use your thighs, not a yank from the rack.

THE MUSCLES THAT PROTECT THE KNEES

Glute bridge

On the mat, on your back, heels close to your hips. Lift the hips, squeeze, lower slowly. Do not arch the low back. 10 reps. When 10 is easy, rest the empty bar across your hips and keep the reps smooth.

PICKING THINGS UP ON A TRAIL

Hip hinge

Empty bar. Soft knees, push the hips back, bar stays against the legs, stop before the back rounds. Stand up by pushing the floor away. 8 reps. This is not a squat and it is not a stiff-legged pull.

THE CHICABAL STAIRS

Step-down, on the tile step by the door

Hold the wall. Stand on the low step. Lower one foot to the floor over a slow count of three. Touch the floor lightly and come back. 6 each leg. The knee of the standing leg tracks over the toes and does not cave in. This is the most useful exercise in the plan. Going down is what bothers sensitive knees, and Chicabal is a long staircase down to the lake and back up.

ON THE HOME GYM

Lat pulldown

Light enough for 10 smooth reps. Pull toward the upper chest. Do not lean back and yank. Control the bar on the way up.

CARRYING A BAG WHILE YOU WALK

Farmer hold

Hold a plate in each hand, or the empty bar in front of you. Stand tall for 30 seconds. Two times. Shoulders down, ribs quiet.

Strength B — support

Thursday. Warm up with 5 easy minutes on the elliptical.

ON THE HOME GYM

Pec deck, light

10 reps. Do not let the arms slam open behind you. Stop the stretch while it still feels easy on the shoulders. If the shoulders complain, skip this and do push-ups with your hands on the bench instead, body in a straight line, 8 reps.

ON THE HOME GYM

Lat pulldown again, or a seated row

10 reps. If the machine has a low pulley, use a row this day and save the pulldown for Monday. Pull the shoulders back at the end, then let them return slowly.

HIPS

Side leg lift

Lie on the mat on your side. Lift the top leg slightly back, not so high that the hip rolls. 10 each side. Small and controlled.

LOWER LEGS

Calf raise

Hold the rack. Rise up, then lower slowly. 12 reps. Two feet. Only try one foot later, and only if the knee is happy.

ONLY IF IT IS PAINLESS

Light hamstring curl

Use the leg station only on the curl setting, very light, 10 reps. Skip the heavy leg extension. Straightening the knee against a heavy pad is a common way sensitive knees get angry. If the curl hurts the knee at all, leave the station alone.

TRUNK, FOR A LONG WALK

Dead bug, then bird dog

Dead bug: on your back, arms toward the ceiling, knees bent. Lower the opposite arm and leg without letting the low back peel off the mat. 6 each side. Bird dog: on hands and knees, reach the opposite arm and leg, hips still. 6 each side.

Elliptical

Keep the stride comfortable. If a higher resistance makes you pound or lock the knees, back the resistance off and shorten the stride a little. You are practicing hours of walking, not a sprint.

Weeks	Tuesday steady	Friday hills	Saturday long
Oct 5 and Oct 12	30 min, your usual pace	8 min easy, then 2 hard / 2 easy, four times	30 min continuous
Oct 19 and Oct 26	35 min	Same, five rounds	35, then 40 min
Nov 2 and Nov 9	35–40 min	Six rounds	45 min. On Nov 9, wear the sling for the last 10.
Nov 16	40 min	Six rounds	50 min, sling for the last 15.
Nov 23	30 min easy	Four easy rounds	40 min easy, no sling. This week is a taper.

If you already do more than 30 minutes, stay at your current time for the first two weeks. Add 5 minutes to the long day every two weeks after that. Do not jump straight to 50.

“Hard” on Friday means the legs are working and you can still say a short sentence. It does not mean gasping. The easy parts are where the knee gets to calm down.

What you are training for

Cerro Quemado on December 5 is a short walk, out and back in under two hours, and you turn around on time. Chicabal on December 6 is the real one: a path up, then a long staircase down to the lake and back up. The step-downs are for that staircase. The long elliptical is for being on your feet that whole morning.

Xela and Chicabal sit much higher than San Salvador. Fitter legs help. The air will still feel thin on the first hills. Walk slowly. That is the plan on the trip, and it is a success, not a failed workout.

The week you leave

November 30 and December 1: 20 easy minutes on the elliptical, or a full rest. No new exercises. No heavy step-downs. You want ordinary legs on the bus, not sore ones.

On the trip, the elliptical habit is replaced by the walking. You do not need a workout in the hotel. Stretch the calves on the tile step after the two hike days, gently, and stop if the knee pinches.

Equipment this uses: the elliptical, the flat bench, the bar, the mat, the pulldown on the home gym, and the low tile step by the door. Nothing new to buy.